

SEALED SOLUTION

# Stop here until you commit.

This file reveals the investigation, the identities, and the ending. Keep it separate from the player packet.

Before continuing, write your conclusion, cite the records that support it, and name an uncertainty the file does not resolve.

Read the evidence-cited solution first. The expanded aftermath follows the original ending. It develops the human consequences; it does not supply a clue needed to solve the case.

A blank reverse follows this cover so the first answer starts on a fresh sheet when this file is printed on both sides.

SPOILER BARRIER

# The answer is overleaf.

Keep this file closed until your written reconstruction is complete.

# The rightful successor

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**Ada Finch, born Ada Bell on 5 March 1888, is entitled to the entire Ashcombe Estate at 6:15 a.m. on 20 September 1913.**

Her qualifying descent is **Gideon Ashcombe → Frances Ashcombe (Bell) → Robert Bell → Ada Bell (Finch)**.

Frances is Gideon's eldest child. Her elder child is Robert. Robert's only child is Ada. Frances and Robert died before the cutoff; R4 preserves the priority of their branch. Ada was living at the required instant and has filed no relinquishment. R8 selects her before the inquiry ever reaches Alice Vale or Matthew's branch.

## The order among the eligible living people

| Place | Person            | Reason                                         |
|-------|-------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 1     | Ada Finch         | Senior branch: Frances → Robert                |
| 2     | Peter Vale        | Frances → Alice; Alice relinquished personally |
| 3     | Lawrence Ashcombe | Matthew's elder child                          |
| 4     | Celia Marsh       | Matthew's younger child                        |

Alice Vale is living but is not eligible to receive the estate because E08 is effective under R5. She is bypassed personally; Peter keeps his branch's priority. The rank list sets aside earlier selected people using the same cutoff facts. It predicts no future transfer.

## The central mistake

The dead infant in D-447 is not Robert's daughter. An unfinished index comparison became a claim that an entire branch had ended. Ada's later use of Finch helped that mistaken conclusion persist.

# Prove the identity and descent

| Required link         | Visible proof                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gideon → Frances      | E02: Frances born 18 February 1832, child of Gideon. E04: bride Frances Ashcombe names father Gideon and marries Nathan Bell.                                                                        |
| Frances → Robert      | E05 B-112: Robert born 14 January 1855; parents Nathan Bell and Frances formerly Ashcombe. E04 supports the household continuity.                                                                    |
| Robert → Ada Bell     | E10 B-903: Ada born 5 March 1888 at 4 Mill Lane; parents Robert Bell and Edith formerly Lane. E06 links Robert to the same wife and household.                                                       |
| Ada Bell → Ada Finch  | E12: unchanged birth date, parent particulars, signed surname amendment and continuing employee number 27. E13 confirms Edith's remarriage to Samuel Finch and the date that prompted the amendment. |
| Alive at the cutoff   | E15: the housekeeper saw Ada Finch, employee 27, at the linen-room table at 6:15 a.m. on 20 September. The later signed wage receipt corroborates continuing life.                                   |
| No personal exclusion | E16: E08 is the only registered relinquishment, and no other exclusion applies. Ada is not its signer.                                                                                               |

The records join through multiple particulars. A shared name alone would not establish this route. R2 recognizes the recorded descent, R6 permits supported identity across surnames, and R4 requires survival at the specified instant.

# Resolve every superior position

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| Position examined               | Disposition and support                                                                                                               |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gideon / root                   | Not a candidate under R2; begin with his children.                                                                                    |
| Frances / eldest child          | Born 1832, before Matthew (1835) and Julian (1841), E02. Died 1899. Bypass her personally under R4 and remain in her branch.          |
| Robert / Frances's elder child  | Born 1855, before Alice (1858), E05. Died 1904, E06. Bypass him personally under R4 and examine his child.                            |
| Ada / Robert's child            | One child, B-903, under E16; identity and survival proved in E10, E12-E15. Select under R8. No earlier descendant remains unresolved. |
| Alice / Frances's younger child | Living under E16, but personal relinquishment E08 predates cutoff. R5 preserves her son's priority.                                   |
| Peter / Alice's child           | E07 proves descent; E16 proves life and sole-child scope. He follows Ada when Ada alone is set aside.                                 |
| Matthew's branch                | E02 places it after Frances's entire branch. Matthew died in 1905. Lawrence (1863) precedes Celia (1868). E16 closes their issue.     |
| Julian's branch                 | Last child of Gideon; outgoing holder and deceased, with no children, E02/E16.                                                        |

E16 certifies complete branch counts, no extra children and the complete relinquishment register. It deliberately leaves the B-903/D-447 identity comparison to the player. Its completeness is a stated fictional case fact under R7, not an inference from census omissions or the petitioners' shortlist.

# Why the rival readings fail

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## Peter's claim

Peter correctly identifies Frances as the senior branch and correctly preserves his own place after Alice's personal relinquishment. His decisive error is treating the copied death-index line as Robert's child. Robert's branch has priority over Alice's, and Ada survives within it.

## The two Ada Bells

| Particular | B-903 / rightful line | D-447 / deceased child          |
|------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------|
| Birth      | 5 March 1888          | 12 February 1888 (linked B-891) |
| Place      | 4 Mill Lane, Millford | 9 Harbour Street, Bracken       |
| Father     | Robert Bell / joiner  | Walter Bell / dock labourer     |
| Mother     | Edith, formerly Lane  | Jane, formerly Pike             |

E12 also positively records Robert and Edith's daughter in service in 1905, long after the other child's death. The mistake is demonstrable; the player need not assume that every death record is wrong.

## Lawrence's claim

Lawrence has a genuine qualifying relationship through Matthew. R2 imposes no sex or surname restriction, however, and R3 completes Frances's elder branch before Matthew's. He is eligible but lower in priority.

## The household return

E14 says Edith had no children in her present marriage to Samuel. That does not deny her child from her earlier marriage to Robert. The recorded word Daughter describes Ada's household relationship to Samuel, not a new parentage that extinguishes the birth-record relationship.

## An acceptable answer

Award the case on the quality of the cited proof, not an exact wording match. A correct name without the identity bridge, branch priority and competing-claim analysis is an incomplete determination.

# The door she used

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Harcourt found Ada at the linen-room table, folding a sheet along a seam she had repaired herself. He had rehearsed his announcement in the corridor. It sounded absurd beside the practical business of a house that still needed putting in order.

| *There is a matter concerning your father, Miss Finch.*

She looked up. Most people in the house meant Samuel when they said her father. Harcourt put a copy of the birth entry on the table and waited until she had read Robert's name.

Her mother had kept Bell for three years after the funeral. Finch had come later, with a smaller cottage, a steadier wage and a man who never made either of them feel borrowed. Ada had changed the name in the wage book because the housekeeper asked which name to write. She had not understood that anyone might lose her in the change.

Harcourt explained the settlement. He explained the branches and the dead child with the same name. When he reached the unfinished memorandum, Ada read its final pencilled instruction twice.

| *He knew he had not checked it.*

Harcourt did not defend the sentence. He placed the determination beside it.

At the front of the house Lawrence and Peter waited in the drawing room. Ada had entered that room hundreds of times with folded linen or a message. This time Harcourt asked whether she would like him to speak first.

She shook her head, took the keys, and went through the door she had always been told to leave closed.

## Author's note

This ending supplies an imagined response after the proved result. It adds no fact required to solve the case. The investigation ends with the evidence-backed determination on the preceding pages.

## AFTER THE CASE

# The question after the front door

After the original solution and continuation

After Ada entered by the front door, there was a silence in which everyone seemed to expect her to become a different kind of person.

She remained Ada Finch. She knew where the linen was kept and which passages led most quickly through the house. She did not suddenly know how to supervise a fund or distinguish useful advice from an attempt to take over her decisions.

Harcourt set the determination before her. Gideon, Frances, Robert, Ada. The first surviving eligible person in the eldest branch, alive at the fixed instant. Peter followed her; Lawrence and Celia came after him. Alice's registered act excluded Alice personally. It had not erased her son. Ada's changed surname had not erased Robert's child.

"I should like to read it myself," Ada said.

"Of course."

She heard the ease of that reply and wondered how much of it depended on what the determination had just made her. Agnes had respected her signature on the payroll before anyone followed it toward a settlement. Ada did not intend to forget the difference.

Celia waited while she read. Lawrence had questions about management. Peter had questions about the old note. They were questions someone would eventually need to address, but neither was permission to speak first for Ada.

"In a moment," she told them.

Peter looked at the memorandum. "I believed it."

Ada had no evidence requiring her to call that a lie. She also did not have to make him comfortable with the effect of believing it.

"You used it to say the line had ended."

He nodded. There was no quick repair available in the room.

Celia asked whether Ada wanted a chair nearer the window. Ada accepted. It was an offer she could answer without surrendering the rest of the conversation. Of the people who had hoped to inherit, Celia was the one giving her that much space.

The house would not become fair merely because a servant had been correctly identified as its successor. Wages, work, and dependence did not vanish at the front door. Ada had inherited the property under a fictional settlement, not proof that she would manage every part of it wisely.

She finished reading and asked Harcourt to show her what she would next be responsible for. Then she asked Agnes to sit down while they discussed it.